Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the ruling BJP at the Centre were forced to back down and repeal the new farm laws, the party has been in a slump in Punjab, with the cadre demoralised and the support base shrinking. The party soon turned to engineering defections in the Congress and SAD to shore up the state unit. Manpreet is only the latest in the string of renegades who have crossed over, including former Congress chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh and his family. Of course, these leaders come with their own baggage of factionalism, corruption allegations and jockeying for prime positions. Already, there are rumblings—some of the defectors have refused to attend party meetings until they get what they were promised. As expected, all this has left the core BJP cadre fuming.

Manpreet's move comes after his defeat in the recent assembly polls and the elevation of arch-rival Amarinder Singh Raja Warring as Congress state unit chief. Like his friend and former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi, Badal had been out of the country from May to November last year, and perhaps the time away made him realise that his career was going nowhere with the Congress. Manpreet is now back in Bathinda to meet local councillors and will be hoping to give the BJP its first mayor in the region. It'll be a tough ask, though, to reinvent himself for the saffron party.

In the past eight years, the BJP has been in an expansion phase across the country and Punjab, too, has been on the party's radar. The rural electorate here has seen a major churn since the 2015 Guru Granth Sahib sacrilege incident and the resultant protests. Resentment has been building up on issues such as the appointment of encounter specialists from the terror-filled 1980s and '90s as top cops, delay in transfer of capital Chandigarh to Punjab, and the dwindling number of Sikhs in top positions in the judiciary and bureaucracy. The allegations of corruption and drug trafficking against certain Akali Dal leaders and others have added fuel to the fire. Analysts even say the huge protests by the farmers' unions in 2020-21 was a byproduct of this discontent boiling over. In the 2022 assembly polls, it was the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) that walked away with the prize due to the simmering resentment. Almost a year after its sweeping win, AAP's support base is also becoming restive.

Amid all this flux, there is a feeling that the Punjab electorate is looking beyond the

PUNJAB'S MODIFIED CONGRESSMEN

CAPT. AMARINDER SINGH



Two-time Congress CM merged his shortlived Punjab Lok Congress with the BJP. Now member of party's national executive

MANPREET BADAL



SAD chief Sukhbir Badal's cousin, he moved to the Congress and is now in the BJP. Likely to be LS candidate from Bathinda against Harsimrat Badal

RANA GURMIT SINGH SODHI



Close confidant of Amarinder Singh and an ex-minister. Now a special invitee to the BJP national executive

SUNIL JAKHAR



Son of former Lok Sabha speaker Balram Jakhar and ex-Punjab Congress chief is a BJP national executive member

RAJ KUMAR VERKA



Minister in Charanjit Channi's cabinet. Now vice-president of BJP state unit; Valmiki Dalit face of party

ARVIND KHANNA



Two-time MLA and businessman with influence in the Sangrur-Barnala belt. Now BJP state vice-president

LAKHWINDER GARCHA



Former Mohali councillor ran Amarinder's campaign in 2022. Now BJP state vice-president

FATEH SINGH BAJWA



The Qadian MLA is the younger brother of Congress leader of the opposition Pratap Singh Bajwa. Now BJP state vice-president

KEWAL DHILLON



The former minister had been sidelined by the Congress. Now BJP state vice-president

BALBIR SIDHU



Health minister in Amarinder regime. Joined BJP in June 2022; very active in Mohali area

SUNDER SHYAM ARORA



Minister in Amarinder government. Yet to be adjusted in BJP. Arrested by state vigilance bureau in graft case

PARMINDER BRAR



Amarinder confidant is now secretary in BJP state unit. Plays pivotal role in engineering defections in opposition parties